

1 Defining the Subject

Not too many years ago it was part of the received wisdom that the history of scientific or philosophical subjects was entirely distinct from the subject itself; that there is the *doing* of psychology, sociology, economics, physics, etc., and then there is the *history* of such fields. We know better now. Although there are still important differences to be noted, we are more prepared to acknowledge that all intellectual pursuits arise within, and to some extent must bear the marks of, their historical and cultural contexts. This is so not only for the obvious reason that major issues are generally bequeathed rather than suddenly born, but also because the entire enterprise of creating knowledge and solving problems of a given kind is itself a continuing tradition, a culture in its own right. This does not prevent the development of new fields and modes of inquiry, nor does it deny the occasional genius a chance to fashion the unexpected. Rather, it is this culture of knowledge, this culture of thought, that comes to establish the very standards of novelty and usefulness and proceeds to confer meaningfulness and significance on just such efforts.

To refer to a “culture of knowledge” is to introduce a set of traditions that transcend ethnic, national, religious, and racial distinctions, traditions that may be said to pertain to something close to our basic humanity. Indeed, free and imaginative inquiry, seemingly idle speculation, argument and spirited discourse, the play of the mind—these are so central to what we take to be part of a flourishing life that we pity or condemn societies and governments unwilling to permit or nurture such activities.

Psychology as a discipline and as a profession is one of the creations of the culture of thought. Just how it was brought about, how the psychological life of individual persons was objectified and externalized and thus made a subject of study, forms an important chapter in the cluttered book of human initiative. But in its current form, psychology is so various, so partitioned into separate provinces, that the nonspecialist might pardonably conclude that there is

no unified subject at all. This state of affairs, too, is the result of historical developments.

Inevitably, it is a subject's history that defines it, and this is perhaps especially the case with psychology, which William James playfully referred to as "that nasty little subject." It has been at the center of speculation and inquiry since ancient times. Contrary to an all too common claim, it is not in any sense a "young subject," even if its extensive experimental programs are relatively recent. On the latter point, too, one must remain mindful that experimental science within the context of university life is fairly recent in all subject areas. It was not until the first half of the nineteenth century that separate university facilities were provided for research in chemistry, the pioneer here being Liebig in Germany. Of course, academic philosophers and scientists had engaged in research long before this, but only in the nineteenth century do we find the beginning of a tradition that includes experimental science as a recognized and official part of the university's functions. Thus, the founding of psychology's first laboratory by Wundt at Leipzig in 1879 takes place only a little later than the establishment of such laboratories in any discipline.

Might psychology, however, be regarded as young at least in one sense? For was not research undertaken in medicine and in the physical sciences since ancient times, even if not within the context of university studies? This is a more difficult question, for it pertains to activities not readily dated, and to activities not easily defined. Just what, after all, qualifies as scientific research? And what must the subject of the research be to qualify as psychological? There is much in the surviving works of Aristotle to establish that he undertook systematic studies of perception, emotion, and behavior in the animal kingdom. His writings on psychological matters are often detailed and technical, and refer to processes now routinely featured in psychological experiments and courses. Accordingly, it would be entirely proper to date the origins of psychological research and of scientific theories about psychological processes with Aristotle, thus pushing back the birth of this part of the subject to the fourth century B.C. Comparable claims could then be made for most of the succeeding centuries, for in nearly all of them one can find a record of scientific or medical inquiry pertaining to psychological states, processes, or attributes.

The tendency, common in books on the history of psychology, to regard the subject as young or immature arises from uncritically accepted positions on just what the essence of psychology is. If on some distant reckoning the (unlikely) conclusion were reached that the issues of central concern to psychology are utterly unsuited to experimental modes of inquiry, there would surely be no reason to examine early experimental projects in order to date its birth. Only after taking a settled position on just what sort of subject psychology is does it make sense to focus on Wundt and the Leipzig laboratory or, for that matter, on Plato's dialogues.

can only understand with context of hist + culture
(no universal laws).

phil history vs biology

But the tendency to consider psychology young arises also from an uncritical belief that similar actions taking place in radically different epochs can be understood as arising from similar aims and perspectives. The ancient astrologers constructed star-charts and models of celestial behavior, activities not unlike what is now found in the fields of cosmology and astrophysics. The ancient astrologers, however, based their efforts on a perspective and a set of assumptions now judged to be nothing more than superstitions. Any definition that takes psychology to be just what the psychologists of a given era might be doing is bound to be misleading and ill conceived. First, absent a more fundamental definition, there would be no way of identifying the participants as psychologists in the first place. Secondly, unless the activities and inquiries are merely reflections of personal interests, including quirky ones, what psychologists undertake must be addressed to some set of issues or problems bequeathed to them by earlier students of the subject. Clearly, then, important fields of study cannot be fully understood solely in terms of current practices, or by recording apparently similar inquiries taking place over long stretches of time. To comprehend the nature of psychology and find a definition that establishes both its uniqueness and its relatedness to other subjects, the study of its history becomes essential.

The Idea of History

It is generally thought to be of importance to a man that he should know himself: where knowing himself means knowing not his merely personal peculiarities, the things that distinguish him from other men, but his nature as a man. . . . Knowing yourself means knowing what you can do; and since nobody knows what he can do until he tries, the only clue to what man can do is what man has done.

R. G. Collingwood's words appear in the introduction to his *The Idea of History*.¹ Following his precepts one might say that the best sense of what psychology is and the most tutored guesses as to what it might become, are developed under the light of its history, the record of what has been *done* in its name (or in all but its name). But as Collingwood goes on to explain, there is more to the study of history than marking down names and dates. History, for Collingwood, is a species of science; it answers questions by identifying the causes and conditions by which historical events came about:

Science in general . . . does not consist in collecting what we already know and arranging it in this or that kind of pattern. It consists in fastening upon something we do not know, and trying to discover it.²

To know, then, that Wundt secured funds to establish a laboratory at Leipzig in 1879, or that Freud wrote lengthily on the interpretation of dreams at the end of that same century, is to be in possession of facts, but not of the explanations that give meaning to the facts. It is to know nothing that points to the rationale, to the impulses behind such undertakings; nothing that discloses the basis upon which either of these important figures in the history of psychology chose his subject or undertook such significant projects. None of this, however, should be taken as a plea for memoirs (as important as these sometimes are). Only if memory were perfect and impartial, and only if commentators were accurate and in full agreement, would the historian's mission be abbreviated or unnecessary, usefully replaced by memoirs. Memories are imperfect and incomplete, sometimes selective, often rhetorical in their deployment. Even the letter-perfect memory of the camera yields a record seen from one direction only. The camera sometimes faces away from the real action and, in any case, never has a view so wide as to capture that full context that gives meaning to the particulars.

To put the matter briefly, there is no dispensing with *interpretation* when seeking to understand complex, unfolding, incomplete events and ideas. Where intellectual history is at issue, the relevant contexts go beyond the compass of any observer's memory. Such a history is comprised of words, and these, unlike swords and tanks and the exchange-rates of currency, are used differently at different times, often intending more than they convey. Intellectual histories are thwarted by all the obstacles facing other forms of historical inquiry, and then some. The thin lines of evidence diverge while the actual witnesses, out of ignorance or fear or sloth or confusion, fail to reflect accurately the ideas of their period. In this way the words themselves obstruct a later reckoning; in addition, modern analysts then enter with their own biases and confusions, further darkening the record.

These biases were insightfully exposed by Giovanni Battista Vico (1668–1744),³ one of the first great historians of the modern era. He warned of the constant temptation to revere antiquity beyond all sense of proportion. This prejudice not only colors our evaluations but may even lead to quantitative errors, errors in estimating wealth or population or longevity. He also recognized the subtle chauvinist who writes about his own people in large case.

Most common of all blunders, Vico noted, is the tendency to identify the character of an age by studying the thoughts of its scholars. Vico recognized that scholars often are not at all representative of the time in which they live. They differ from their contemporaries in interests, in schooling, even in basic values. The importance of understanding Aristotle's theory of the soul or Socrates' conception of virtue cannot be to learn "the Athenian" understanding of such notions. The average Athenian, more likely than not, seldom considered such matters and, had he been privileged to discuss them with Aristotle or

Socrates, might well have found the philosophers' treatments bizarre. If we would unearth the popular views on subjects of this sort, we would have to search the myths and rites of antiquity, the poems and correspondence and plays of the age. Once the commoner understandings are thus located, they are nearly invariably different from the sage's.

Vico also warned against imputing too much credibility to those who have provided eyewitness accounts. The fact that Tacitus wrote about events in his own time does not mean that he was conceptually closer to them. He wore the distorting lenses of his epoch. His travels were limited. He spoke and read in but two languages. His resources were saddled to a primitive technology. Lacking the methods of modern scholarship (methods only recently developed by linguists, archeologists, physicists, etc.), a Tacitus or a Herodotus or a Livy could examine earlier eras only through the eyes and fables of those who came before.

Finally, Vico presents the pervasive error of *scholastica successionis civitatum*, the "scholastic succession (or bequest) of states." This error moves us to believe that when an intellectual development occurs sequentially in two different countries, it occurs in the second through the direct influence of the first. Since, for example, Adelardus spoke in the twelfth century of the earth's motion and since Copernicus was generous in his reading habits, Copernicus must have got the idea from Adelardus (or Cicero or Aristarchus or Nicole Oresme, etc.). According to this view, an idea is the pebble of a uniquely enlightened time dropped by philosophers on the calm lake of slumbering minds. The idea disturbs first one culture, then the next, *seriatim*. The historian's challenge is to work back from the ripples to the source and, thereby, to discover the first source of all our wisdom. Vico, as with Aristotle earlier, knew that such orderly succession was seldom the case. Ours is a questioning and a theorizing species which does not rest at length. There is hardly a notion prized by any age that was not entertained by many others at many different times and quite independently. Accordingly, a mere chronology of ideas would not only fail to be a history of ideas but would fail to be true. We can say, with measurable confidence, that an event of a certain kind occurred for the first time or, at least, that no earlier record has been found. But we cannot date the first appearance of a thought or a point of view with similar precision.

The Greeks invented philosophy as a discipline, as a form of inquiry regulated by rules and organized around a set of questions. They were, in this narrow sense, the first philosophers. But it would be ridiculous to argue that Thales was the first human being to recognize that "it is hard to be good." We explore the history of ideas to learn how others have dealt with problems facing us, what others have considered important, and the factors that seemed to have caused events of consequence. One inescapable product of our study is a chronology, but this is surely not the goal. We expect the historian to tell us when

things happened much as we expect the modern astronomer to tell us the position of the planets on the day Caesar was killed. But we expect much more. We believe the astronomer because his calculations are based on laws—laws fashioned in the light of criticism, objective measurement, and multiple observations—and we expect as much from the historian. Not that the explanations will unfold inexorably from the fixed “laws” of history, but that they will be framed according to the very best evidence available and will, therefore, yield the truest picture of what happened and why it happened.

In the epilogue to *The Idea of History*, Collingwood ventures, with characteristic decisiveness, to place psychology in perspective. He argues that psychology's chief mistake was to identify with the physical sciences and by that strategy to adopt methods wholly unsuited and even futile to its enterprise. Psychology, Collingwood insists, can answer its questions only by transforming its methods into those of history:

To regard [psychology] as rising above the sphere of history, and establishing the permanent and unchanging laws of human nature, is therefore possible only to a person who mistakes the transient conditions of a certain historical age for the permanent conditions of human life.⁴

It is not necessary to accept these prescriptions for psychology in order to appreciate the subtler point he raises. A science concerned with the determinants of human conduct, with the character of human perception and emotion, will find in the annals of civilization a laboratory more varied and rich than any we could hope to re-create. This part of Collingwood's instruction is unimpeachable, and it is this part that urges us to study history if we are to study psychology.

In attempting what has been described as an intellectual history, therefore, one is committed to something different from chronology. And, in attempting an intellectual history of psychology, one must be concerned with far more than academic psychology. This said, the following pages may seem to belie the premise, for, in fact, a chronological succession does follow. This, however, is a concession to custom and convenience and is not to be viewed as the fallacy of *scholastica successionis civitatum*. One age does not impart momentum to the next as would a pair of colliding billiard balls, though the culture of thought does have its founders and followers. Ideas are kept alive, they do not merely assert themselves. And where important ideas are concerned, those developed within a productive age, it is misleading even to think that the age itself has died.

There is no question but that psychological scholarship, at any time since Socrates, has been influenced by Greek thought. Yet a study of the Socratics is not enough. Succeeding generations did not passively assimilate Plato's dialogues but interpreted them in altered contexts and for diverse purposes. Often

enough the “Greek view” is advanced by a modern who discovers only later that someone else had said very much the same thing. Thus the following chapters could easily have been arranged not as a succession of epochs but as a collection of problems; for example, the problem of knowledge, the problem of conduct, the problem of values. Indeed, if there is anything that one age may be said to inherit directly from its predecessor, it is these problems, and a chronological assessment honors this even as it makes clear just where there has been no real progress at all.

There are, however, at least two disadvantages courted by the “great issues” model. First, it leads to wearying redundancy, since nearly every age has come to advance the same range of answers to the same great questions. To choose one example, informed opinions on the question of human goodness or wickedness are neither broader nor livelier in contemporary scholarship than in the days of Aristotle. Still, although the richness of opinion may not have deepened over the ages, the chains of fact and the rules of evidence have advanced, even if sluggishly. Knowledge, after all, in some compartments is cumulative, and of these compartments a chronological account is appropriate. Knowledge is most cumulative in the sciences and, to the extent that modern psychology seeks membership in the family of science, we are advised to explore the growth of those sciences on which psychology has depended.

Perhaps the more compelling reason for adopting the chronological model (and here an author’s limitations are stripped of all disguise) is simply that it is easier to compile evidence and interpret it within one era at a time. We can say in one sentence that questions of importance and daring answers to them have appeared repeatedly and often independently in every civilized epoch. We can say his, but we cannot show it until books are scored as symphonies and until readers sight-read the simultaneous performances of strings, brass, woodwind, and tympany.

Having adopted, no matter how grudgingly, a sequentialist approach, and knowing that no caveat will be heeded by everyone, there is still the problem of identifying more or less discrete periods of intellectual history. Did the Hellenic Age, for example, ever really end? The world of thought and scholarship still speaks of justice, searches for truth, houses democracies of one stripe or another. Only the more literal-minded would require “Hellenism” to remain in Athens and express itself in the old Greek. And, since all forms of Roman arts and letters were utterly suffused by this same Hellenism, on what conceptual basis do we defend such expressions as *Roman* civilization or the Augustan age? Is the American Constitution an *American* constitution, or is it John Locke’s vision of government? Is it, then, an English constitution or a modified form of Roman Republicanism?

Such questions can be raised to challenge any suggestion of historical discontinuity, and they are valid. The general point can be further illustrated with

a popular example. Suppose we wish to identify a block of time as "the Italian Renaissance" and adopt the conventional dates, 1350 to 1600. In doing so, we are implicitly adopting at least four propositions: first, that there was, at some earlier time, a classical outlook later to be recovered for reborn; second, that this older age vanished or entered a period of prolonged hibernation; third, that at a definable time, the hibernation ended and a renaissance of perspective and achievement took place; and fourth, that this rebirth itself ran a given course only to be replaced by something discriminably different.

These propositions can be sustained or rejected depending on what we choose to make use of when we decide to define an "age." Religiously, the Renaissance mind was probably closer to the neo-Platonism of the Dark Ages than it was to the Thomistic Aristotelianism of the later Middle Ages. If by "renaissance" we mean to imply a rebirth of what made classical Athens famous, we must account for the troubling fact that the Italian Renaissance did not produce a single philosopher of enduring consequence.⁵ As for the vaunted humanism of the period, few Greek philosophers would have found much to recommend in it. But here we anticipate ourselves. The point to be made is that (and with due respect to Vico, Hegel, and Spengler) history is not cyclical, and that what sometimes makes it seem so is the mere recurrence of certain political and philosophical dispositions. The conditions responsible for these are always different the second (third, fourth, etc.) time around. So, in no historically defensible way can we understand the Renaissance as a re-creation of the Athenian *zeitgeist*, or the eighteenth-century Virginia plantation as "medieval." Such descriptions can be no more than metaphorical and can yield ludicrous conclusions.

If we are clear in our recognition of the artificiality of abrupt historical transitions, we can gain the advantage that labels give to memory without suffering the burden they impose on judgment. Since history is neither constant nor cyclical, we must be prepared to discover change without expecting duplication, orderliness but not historic necessity. Where the second billiard ball must move (if our laws in physics are to endure), the King may not. He may, for example, be sleeping. And, as we place people and events under sadly general categories, we must not forget that they are probably more similar to ourselves than different. We have no reason to assume that, because they thought about different matters, they thought in different ways, or that because they perceived their condition differently they either had no perception at all or lacked one that could be defended. "They," after all, are "we"; otherwise our inquiry would be reduced to a kind of comparative anatomy.

If the metaphor of the family is not too homespun, we might profitably view the several epochs as relatives, each with a set of distinguishing features but each nonetheless related to every other: related, but not in a mechanical fashion. Some relatives leave diaries, portraits, photographs, and even handsome

bequests. Others leave only a certain record of good will and tolerance. Still others remain ever a mystery. They said little, traveled less, and wrote nothing. Occasionally, distant cousins show features more in common than brothers, and certain children seem to bear no resemblance at all to either parent.

When we treat historical inquiry as a kind of genealogy, we not only whet our intellectual appetite with a mixture of fancy and vanity but we also set certain traps. We invite the error of *scholastica successionis*. There is no gene for iambic pentameter, for twelve-tone harmony, or for painting madonnas. We do not understand the wealth of Uncle John and the poverty of his brother by exploring their pedigrees. To carry the metaphor to its limit, we do not explain the difference between ages by measuring their breeding practices. Therefore, the sense in which the following chapters are devoted to the various epochs of Western civilization is geographic only. Indeed, had it not been for medieval scholars in the Arab world, the chapter featuring Aristotle's psychological theories might be less than a page.

In light of all this, it should be clear that the idea of history is a kind of theory of explanation. It bears the same sort of relation to the facts of history that, for example, a concept or scientific law bears to the facts of experience. If we can imagine a being equipped with human senses but lacking human concepts, we might expect it to be flooded by sights and sounds that are never brought into a meaningful or even a coherent relationship. Think, for example, of how the events in the world would appear to a being utterly lacking the concept of causation. It is by virtue of our conceptual abilities that otherwise disjointed occurrences finally become explainable. We are able to distinguish between merely correlated and causally related events; between accidents and determined occurrences; between coincidence and lawful conformities. We refer to history as a similar collection of concepts and laws, or, at least, as a conviction that significant historical events can be explained only through a similar sort of rational-cognitive analysis.

At the root of the idea of history lies a judgment on what makes an event historical in the first place. We do not think of every falling leaf or every cry in the night historical, even though such events can be dated and their causes identified. We refuse to classify falling leaves as historical because the concept of history excludes purely physical transactions taking place among items of inanimate matter and embraces those occurrences that seem to require human participation, human striving. Indeed, the ordinary sense of "history" excludes everything that is merely physical. Even cries in the middle of the night take on historical standing only to the extent that they have a significant bearing on the actions of persons, institutions, or whole nations. As a theory of explanation, the idea of history arises from the judgment that events of social, political, moral, or intellectual consequence can only be understood by consulting the perceptions, reasons, intentions, motivations, and comprehensions of those

who lived through the events in question. Even more, the judgment perceives these persons as constituting a sufficient reason for the occurrence of these events. That is, had persons of a different perceptual, intentional, motivational or cognitive makeup been substituted, the same event would not have occurred.

This, however, is not some useless truism. It is, of course, trivially true that had everything been different, things would have been different. But the judgment out of which the idea of history arises does not take stock of "everything," only of some things—specifically, of uniquely human things. It takes for granted that history is something caused by human agency, something that receives its essential character from the specific moral, psychological, and conceptual attributes of actual persons. Note, however, that this is not a silent endorsement of the "great man" theory of history, nor is it an implicit defense of "psycho-history."

To say that events are judged as historical only when they require the assumption of human agency does not say that such agency proceeds from "great" individuals or even nameable persons. Even less does it say that the historical event must be understood in terms of someone's "psychological background," such as early childhood experiences, inferiority complexes, fear of water. Instead, it takes for granted (at least as a working hypothesis) that events in human history proceed from human actions, that the latter proceed from human judgments, and that the events become intelligible to posterity only when connections can be established between the understandings and the actions of the historical participants themselves. History as we know it is the disciplining of empathy by scholarship.

The subject matter of psychology is as old as reflection. Its broad practical aims are as dated as human societies. Human beings, in any period, have not been indifferent to the validity of their knowledge; they have not been unconcerned with the causes of their behavior or that of their prey and predators. Our distant ancestors, no less than we, wrestled with the problems of social organization, child rearing, competition, authority, individual differences, and personal safety. Solving these problems required insights, no matter how untutored, into the psychological dimensions of life.

If we are to follow the convention of treating psychology as a young discipline, we must have in mind something other than its subject matter. We must mean that it is young in the sense that physics was young at the time of Archimedes or in the sense that geometry was "founded" by Euclid and "fathered" by Thales. Sailing vessels were launched long before Archimedes discovered the laws of buoyancy. Pillars of identical circumference were constructed before anyone knew that $C = \pi D$. We do not consider the shipbuilders and stonecutters of antiquity physicists and geometers. Nor were the ancient cave dwellers psychologists merely because they rewarded the good conduct of their children. The archives of folk wisdom contain a remarkable collection of

achievements, but craft, no matter how perfected, is not science, nor is a litany of successful accidents a discipline. If psychology is young, it is young as a scientific discipline, but it is far from clear that it has attained or should have sought to attain this status. In any case, the foundations of the subject predate its scientific aspirations. The foundations are philosophical, and it is to these that we turn in the search for origins.

Notes

1. R. G. Collingwood, *The Idea of History*, Oxford University Press, New York, 1972. This quotation is taken from page 10 of the Introduction. We owe the availability of this work to Professor T. M. Knox, a close associate of Collingwood's, who edited these essays after Collingwood's death in 1943 at the age of 52. His Preface to the edition is important to an understanding of Collingwood's program, of which *The Idea of History* is but illustrative.

2. Collingwood, *Idea of History*, p. 9.

3. The most accessible source for the works of Giovanni Battista (or Giambattista) Vico is the translated edition, *The New Science of Giambattista Vico*, by T. G. Bergen and M. H. Fisch, Cornell University, New York, 1970. This is an abridgement of the 1948 translation by the same translators. Vico's historiographic method is well illustrated in Book Three, the *Discovery of the True Homer*. On his complaint about earlier historians, a delineation of their flaws, and his own approach, see *Elements*, Book One, Sec. II. On the error of *scholastica successionis*, see XIII, 146 of the *Elements*.

4. Collingwood, *Idea of History*, p. 224.

5. This observation will be amplified and explained in Chapter 6, with apologies to Erasmus, Luther, Pico, et al.

-Psych is a study of why history happened.

2 Psychology in the Hellenic Age: From the Pre-Socratics to the Dialogues

Within an area approximating the size of Montana, and over a period of less than three hundred years, the Greek-speaking people of the ancient world would produce the philosophers Thales, Anaxagoras, Empedocles, Parmenides, Zeno, Pythagoras, Protagoras, Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle; the dramatists Aeschylus, Sophocles, Euripides, and Aristophanes; the historians Herodotus, Thucydides, and Xenophon; Hippocrates the physician; Pericles the political leader; Pheidias the sculptor; and the various schools and traditions that would become associated with these names. This span of time, a period covering roughly the appearance of the school or sect of the Pythagoreans in 530 B.C. to the flowering of Aristotle's scholarship two centuries later, comprises the Hellenic epoch of classical Greece, an epoch not anticipated by any prior age.

Having now taken the fateful step toward resurrecting this famous coterie of "dead, white, European males," as some in today's world would have it, a few words are in order concerning the nature of the debt to Hellenism in general. To begin, although the ancient Greeks were suspicious of strangers and more or less convinced of the superiority of their own culture, the leaders of thought in that age did not regard their achievements in racial or ethnic terms. It would take the unifying vision and energy of Alexander the Great to spread Hellenism throughout the conquered territories, but many of these same territories needed little by way of coercion. Moreover, the more enlightened Greeks understood Hellenism itself to be a set of values and attitudes about culture and civilization; about beauty and learning and education; about life within an ordered family and an ordered state. As Isocrates (436–338 B.C.) would express it in his *Panegyrics*, all who shared the Hellenic conception of culture (*paideia*) were "Greek" in the most relevant sense of the term. The extent to which ancient Romans came to share this conception was so considerable that Pliny would declare Rome to be a Greek city! Over the many centuries since that